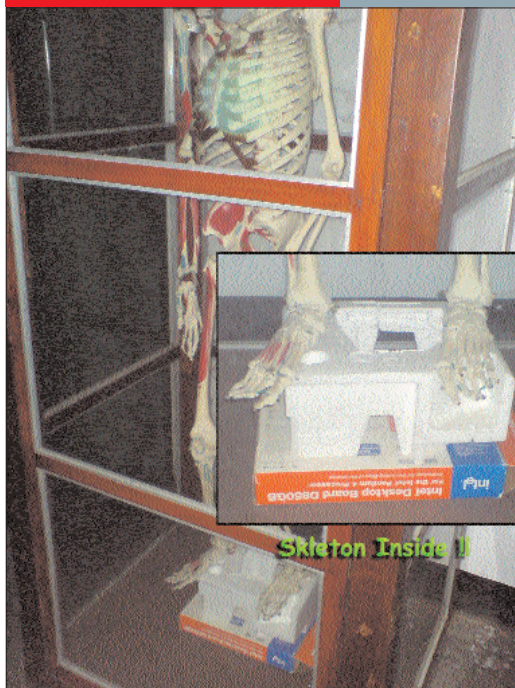


DigiPick of the month

"Bare-bones Hardware"



Last month's winner is

Abhra Bagchi

(abhra_life@yahoo.co.uk)

Participate and win
next month

**The Accredited Symbian
Developer Primer**

by Jo Stichbury & Mark Jacobs

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



Corrigendum: January's winner was
Nadeem Shaikh, Pune.

WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject "**DigiPick**" and your postal address **on or before the 20th of this month** to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

looking for words to describe the probable look on the face of William Henry Gates—and the extent of his speechlessness—when he was told, at the opening of a global technical centre in Bucharest, by Romanian president Traian Basescu, that that country's IT industry would have been nowhere if it weren't for pirated Windows. (And pirated Office, we're presuming.)

Now what, really, do you say in such a situation? "It's my pleasure"? "Don't mention it, it was nothing"? The comment by Basescu was almost certainly a compliment, we think. But communicated as it was to Bill Gates, we're wondering if Basescu was a tad sloshed when he said it. People don't say things!

To give you an idea of the gravity of the situation (the situation in Gates' head, that is), Basescu said during a *joint news conference with Gates* that piracy had helped the younger generation discover computers, that it set off the development of the IT industry in Romania. And Basescu goes on. Piracy also

helped Romanians improve their "creative capacity in the IT industry," which he says is now world-renowned. He said all this piracy "ten years ago" was an investment in Romania's "friendship" with Microsoft and Gates.

The one inaccuracy there is the "ten years ago." Basescu failed to mention that the pirates are still doing their act—and very well indeed. It's not like Romania is suddenly going to go buy genuine Windows—software pirates abound like flies in the country, we're told, and will call up offices peddling their wares.

So what *did* Gates say to the genial Romanian head of state? Nothing, as the reports go. "No comment."

It seems a conspiracy (no pun intended, we promise!)—everyone seems to be telling Gates to loosen up and just take piracy in his stride. There's a Russian teacher who was prosecuted by Microsoft for using pirated MS software, and he faced imprisonment in Siberia if proved guilty. Guess who intervened on the teacher's behalf? Mikhail Gorbachev. He made a plea to end the

prosecution. And Vladimir Putin advocated going after the distributors rather than the users. (The teacher was acquitted.)

So come on, Bill, lighten up! A country thanks you! The ultimate form of flattery is imitation—literally!

TOM AND HARRY AVAILABLE

Dick Taken

As if having a name like Pecker weren't bad enough, publishing executive David Pecker lost the right to own davidpecker.com. This is because according to the World Intellectual Property Center (WIPO), only famous people who *trade* on their name have their right to that domain name.

The WIPO Arbitration and Mediation Center declared that Pecker failed to demonstrate that he had rights to davidpecker.com other than "broad assertions."

Now who else would want davidpecker.com? Well, it's a parking service with ads on it, and it happens to

People Who Changed Computing

50 Years On

Certainly one of the biggest things ever to have happened to computing was the



Reynold Johnson

invention of the hard disk by Reynold Johnson, back in 1956. Reynold's interest in electromechanical devices started in 1933. His first invention was a device for automatically grading multiple choice tests.

Johnson joined IBM in the 1950s, specialising in electromechanical devices. IBM, during the time, wanted to develop a random access memory that could store and retrieve data in seconds—and not in minutes like with magnetic tapes and card files. Johnson and team devised the first working magnetic disk storage in late 1955. The device, named RAMAC (Random Access Method of Accounting Control), was very large and weighed a ton, but it was capable of accessing a file in less than a second.

The first commercial hard drive in 1956 produced by IBM called the RAMAC 305 had fifty 24-inch magnetic disks rotating at 1200 rpm. The disk could store 5 MB, which at the time was high.

Johnson is said to have been a gentle man who never wanted to be in the limelight. He received many awards for his contribution to storage devices, including the Medal of Science in 1986, and the IEEE Award for Advancement of Information Storage Technology in 1992. At the end of his life, Johnson was working on codifying Chinese characters.